

Recognize it

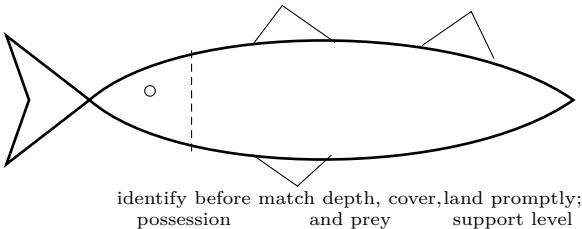
Deep sunfish with a dark flexible ear flap and a blue-black cheek edge.

Body	Compressed oval body; faint bars; breeding males darken at breast.
Mouth/fins	Small mouth; long pointed pectoral fin; continuous spiny dorsal.
Confusion	Pumpkinseed has orange/red on the ear flap and wavy cheek lines.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Vegetation, docks, wood, and firm-bottom nesting colonies.
Food and season
Aquatic insects and small prey; shallow in warm spawning periods, edge-oriented later.

A fish-shaped decision, not a lure list



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test inside weed pockets early, then deep outside weedline and suspended insect layers.
North	Test protected weed bays, docks where access is lawful, and the outside coontail edge.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

- 1. **Float and tiny jig.** Use a small hook or jig with worm segment; set depth so bait stays above weed tops.
- 2. **Vertical micro-jig.** Drop beside deep weeds and watch line for lift bites.
- 3. **Stop rule.** Downsize only after fish are seen; move when small fish dominate and the goal is a modest meal of adults.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Wet hands, cradle the body, and fold the dorsal spines flat from front to back.

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Keep a modest number of mid-size adults; release exceptional males and stop at the meal plan.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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